“neatness,” a contrast to what see senses as the pervasive haunting and lack of reckoning within the historic site.[71]

As a motif, Lorde again uses extra horizontal spatial gaps to emphasize the disjointed character of the scene (“Neatness / wiping memories
payment / from the air”) to convey rhythmic structure, as well as to suggest gaps and silences in the imposed rhythms of historical time and memorial reparation. Rather than granting “neatness” as a simple observation, the spacing and phrasing together conjure a vision that is off-kilter and out of control. Society rushes to move on rather than healing or necessarily talking about its losses and tolls of the past.

Lorde goes on to describe her picnic in the park and lake area that encompasses the memorial park. The bucolic scene becomes eerie and features several juxtaposed images of reproduction and destruction. For example, Lorde describes sitting to eat: “beneath my rump / in a hollow root of the dead elm / a rabbit kindles,” conveying at once a litter of baby rabbits and burning fire. Subsequently, as Lorde ends the picnic, the haunting does not cease. The appearance of a “writhing waterbug,” a roach flicked but split open in her food, symbolizes through interruption the degradation and loss of life, as well as the potential for survival as deterred. As the bug appears, the picnic is halted. Lorde’s line breaks and extra spatial pauses in this stanza convey an unsteady rhythm to this moment. The caesuras in this stanza—between “I stand pick up my blanket” when the bug appears and “cracked open her pale eggs oozing” after the picnic is disturbed—double as physical descriptions of stepping away and breaking open.

In the poem’s final stanza, Lorde marks and pushes the limits of memorial practice, both at the site and in her own poetry. Here she distinguishes between “earth” in the urn and what is not brought forth, “the unremarkable ash” of human remains. She reminds her reader that commemoration cannot fully stand in for the loss of human life. She highlights how this site’s appeal to nature as a form of rebirth doubles as a funereal absence and hinders critical dialogue about violence and history: “careful and monsterless,” she recounts the site’s central memorial vessel, “this urn makes nothing / easy to say.” The collected earth contained in the urn perpetuates a harmful silence. Themes of fractured speech and silence coexist in these lines, as does her clear questioning of sites of cultural memory like Plötzensee. The murdered people she acknowledges, in particular, are Jewish infants and teenage girls. Her gendering of the